

LOOKING INTO THE BRAIN FOR LIE DETECTION

Though the reliability of brain scanning for lie detection is still under question, these tests are fast becoming popular with the crime investigating teams. Here's how they work



A person (left) undergoing polygraph test (courtesy: forensictruthgroup.com)

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Police use lie detectors to crack criminal cases. Based on the signals caught from the criminals, they can decide to proceed the investigation further or not.

Various scientific tools of interrogation are in use, like the psychological tests, narco tests and polygraphic tests. But, their reliability in courtrooms is still an issue. These tests generally don't have legal validity in court and they can only assist police investiga-

tions. At the same time, these lie detection tests prove to be a futile exercise in the case of mastermind criminals.

New technologies are being developed so as to replace the traditional lie detection methods. Here we discuss some of the prevailing and upcoming methods of lie detection.

Psychological test

Psychological tests are usually administered and interpreted by a psychologist. These tests assess and evaluate the information that is given by the crimi-

nal to the examiner. The information is taken either in the form of answers to interview questions or as answers on paper—or on a computer—to specific questions.

Ultimately, the accuracy of a physiological test depends on how carefully and seriously the answers are given. Hence, no psychological test is ever completely valid or reliable because the human psyche is just too complicated to know anything about it with full confidence. That's why there can be uncertainty about a case even after extensive testing.

Narco test

The term 'narco-analysis' is derived from the Greek word 'nark' (meaning 'anesthesia' or 'torpor'). It is a diagnostic and psychotherapeutic technique that uses psychotropic drugs, particularly barbiturates, to induce a stupor in which mental elements with strong associated affects come to the surface, where they can be exploited by the therapist.

The narco analysis test lowers a subject's inhibitions by interfering with his nervous system at the molecular level, in the hope that the subject will more freely share information and feelings. In this state, it becomes difficult though not impossible for him to lie. The subject is not in a position to speak up on his own but can answer specific but simple questions.

The answers are believed to be spontaneous as a semi-conscious person is unable to manipulate the answers. However, crime branch